SYNTHETIC DEMO POLICY — NOT A REAL HEALTH PLAN POLICY

Medical Policy: MRI brain — Coverage criteria

Policy number: RHP-IMG-005 Version: 4.0
Effective date: 2026-01-01 Applies to: Regional Health Plan (all lines)
CPT codes: 70551 (without contrast)

1. Purpose

Defines when outpatient MRI of the brain is medically necessary for members.

2. Covered for headache when ONE red flag is documented

- Sudden severe ('worst ever') headache, or a new headache after age 50
- New neurological deficit, papilledema, confusion or seizure
- Headache with fever and neck stiffness, cancer history or immunosuppression
- Clear change in a long-standing headache pattern
- Headache triggered by exertion, cough or position

3. Also covered

Known or suspected tumor, stroke, multiple sclerosis, or seizure disorder work-up.

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Medical Policy: MRI brain — Documentation and exclusions

4. Required documentation

- Clinical note with headache history, pattern and full neurological exam
- Which red flag (if any) is present

5. Not medically necessary

- Tension-type or migraine headache with a normal neurological exam and no red flags
- Imaging requested for reassurance only

6. Review

A nurse reviewer applies these criteria. Requests that do not meet them are referred to a medical director. Only a medical director may issue an adverse determination.

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